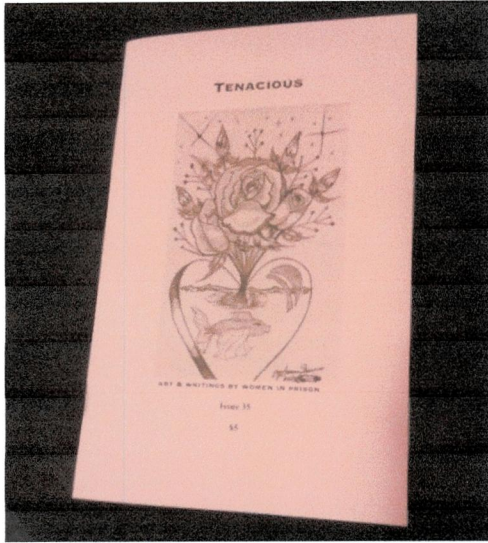


**THE DAMAGE DONE:
An Addict's Experience in Prison**

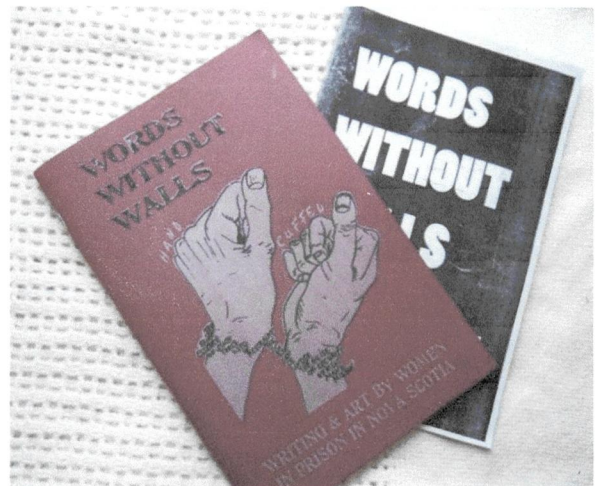
Sara Clouston
Penal Policy
Professor Michael Jackson
UBC Department of Law
April 15, 2016

Zines



Tenacious: Art & Writings by Women in Prison

**Words Without Walls:
Writing & Art by Women in
Prison in Nova Scotia**



Overview

Individuals in federal prisons in Canada with substance abuse issues who want treatment for their addiction face particular realities and hurdles to rehabilitation and reintegration. This paper will expand on the issues raised in the zine, and consider the objectives of the *Corrections and Conditional Release Act (CCRA)* as they relate to substance abuse, and how Correctional Services Canada (CSC) is living up to these objectives. The CSC's current approach has measured success, however evidence suggests there is need for improvement in order to 1) meet existing needs of incarcerated individuals in federal prisons with substance abuse issues, 2) meet the stated objectives in the *CCRA*, and 3) meet international health and human rights standards¹.

¹ Ruth Elwood Martin, Jane A. Buxton, Megan Smith, & T. Gregory Hislop, "The scope of the problem: The health of incarcerated women in BC", *BC Medical Journal* 54:10, December 2012, p 502-508 at (<http://www.bcmj.org/articles/scope-problem-health-incarcerated-women-bc#a4>).

Living with Addiction

Addiction has a particular power to cause those caught in its grips to behave in ways they normally wouldn't. It is characterized in part by an obsession with using a substance to the extent that it has unwanted affects on one's life². At the same time, an addict's chosen substance can provide a way to deal with difficult internal and external circumstances. For Lorri-Anne Cope, an Aboriginal woman who did a six-year sentence at the Okimaw Ohci Healing Lodge in Saskatchewan, described the conflicted relationship an addict has with their substance in a poem titled "Dear Cocaine":

...At this point in my life, I don't miss you but at one point in my life I felt you were my only support. I'd like to say thank-you for helping me through my hard times. You helped me numb most of my hurt. You helped me forget most of my troubles but this was only temporary relief. We had quite the relationship and have done some crazy things together. you gave me power then that I would never need again.

Now I see you as a weakness. Throughout your support I forgot my inner strengths and I also forgot how important I am to my loved ones. I became dependent on you. ... In the company of you I let almost all the things that were important to me slip away and none of that mattered to me as long as I had you. ... Then I realized where I was and why I was there. I began to think about reality and how wrong our relationship was. I began to think about what I let slip out of my reach and to be honest it was just about everything in my life³.

² "DSM-IV Substance Dependence Criteria", *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Health Disorders*, Washington DC: American Psychiatric Association, 2000 at https://www.danya.com/dlc/bup/pdf/Dependence_DSM.PDF.

³ *Prison Voices*, ed. Lee Weinstein & Richard Jaccoma, The John Howard Society of Canada, Fernwood Publishing, 2007 at p 49.